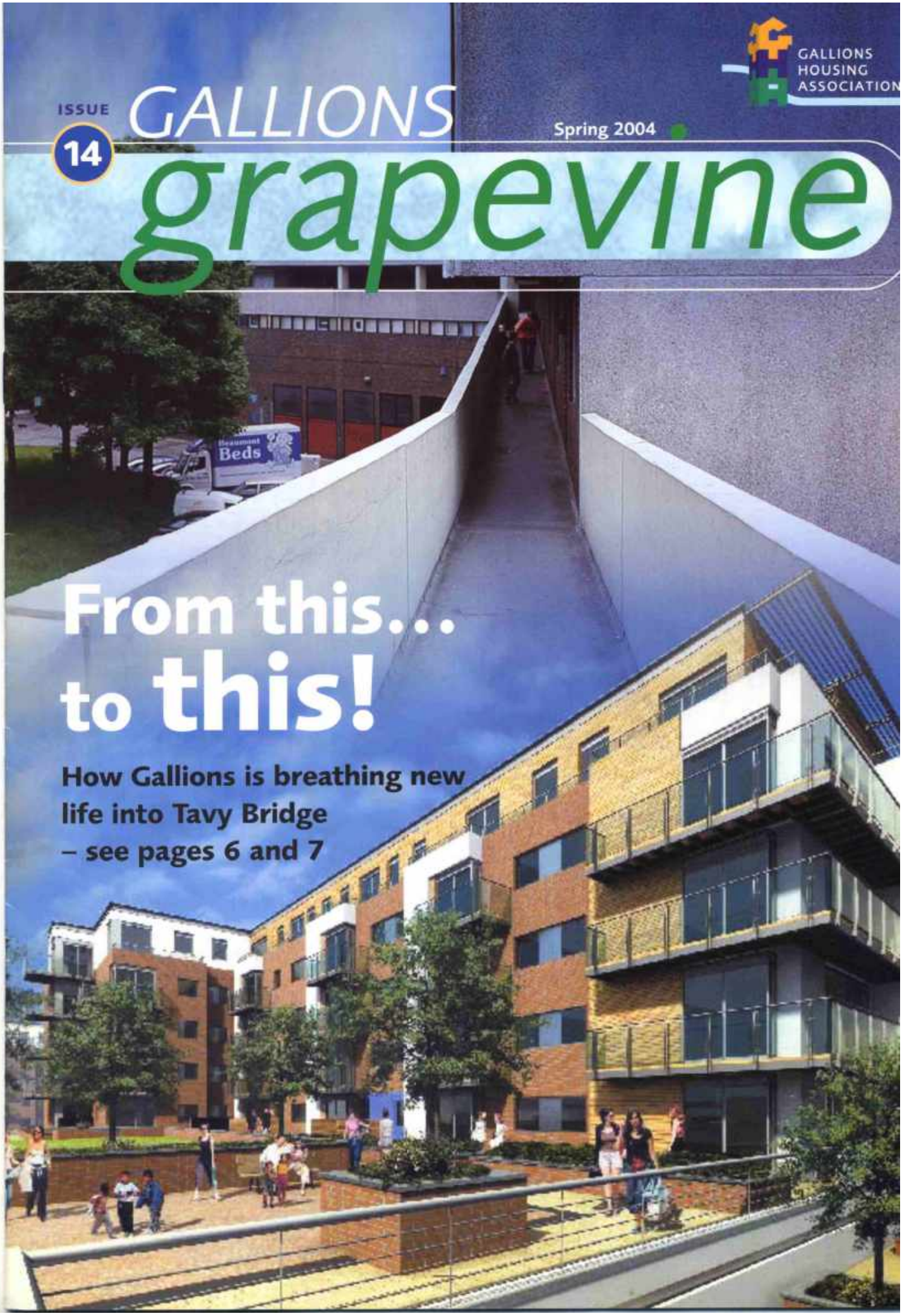
ISSUE 14

GALLIONS grapevine

Spring 2004

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION



From this... to this!

How Gallions is breathing new life into Tavy Bridge
– see pages 6 and 7

Hot off the Press!

ons' News • Gallions' News • Gallions' News • Gallions' News



Gallions' Rebecca Miller receives the award from former tennis star Annabel Croft

Ecopark Strikes Gold in What House? Awards

Gallions' Ecopark walked away with Gold at this year's prestigious Daily Telegraph What House? Awards, which have been dubbed 'the Oscars for the house building industry'.

The awards ceremony was dominated by the country's top private house developers, but when it came to the category of Best Energy Saving Development, the spotlight fell on Gallions.

As Gallions' first sustainable housing scheme, the Ecopark development of 39 houses was designed and built to maximise energy efficiency and reduce water consumption. It has aroused interest from housing associations, private developers and contractors, as well as a wide range of individuals and school parties.

The formal judges' report said, "The entries for this year's Best Energy Saving Development show that you can achieve high standards of build with both an innovative approach and a traditional one. That said, there was a clear winner in our minds whose design embraces high energy efficiency standards going well beyond the regulations."

The awards generate a lot of interest from private house developers around the country, and they show that Housing Associations such as Gallions have much to offer in relation to innovative building schemes.



National Achievement Award for Wardens

The Neighbourhood Wardens have been awarded the 'Neighbourhood Warden Achievement Award for Innovation' by the Office of the Deputy Prime Minister. The award, for the Wardens' Radio Controlled Car Club (WRCCC), included a cheque for £1000 to help the Wardens run the club and the scheme.

The club forms part of the Wardens' new community project aimed at involving young people in fun activities. Since the award was made, other warden schemes around the country have contacted Gallions and expressed interest in setting up similar clubs.

The Wardens hope that, by the end of February, there will be enough warden schemes taking part in the initiative to begin inter-club car championships. This is a fantastic opportunity for young people throughout the country to meet and compete with their peers and to visit new areas.

The WRCCC website will be the focal point for information on the progress of the Wardens' Radio Controlled Car Club, and provide an opportunity for other warden schemes to exchange ideas.

For more details visit www.wrccc.org.uk

Tee at Last!

Gallions sponsored the Black History Month celebrations recently by providing performers with specially designed Black History Month T-shirts. Hundreds of people attended the community celebrations organised by the Thamesmead Youth Awareness Programme.

The Mayor of Bexley, Councillor Denis Daniels, inaugurated the proceedings, and Bexley's cabinet member for social inclusion, community cohesion and housing, Councillor Manny Blake, attended the gala performance.





Three's Company in Community Safety Zone

Police Sergeant Neil Stevenson has joined PC Tim Lawlor and PC Rob Evans as a ward officer at Thamesmead East.

"I am delighted to be working in Thamesmead," said an obviously delighted and enthusiastic Sergeant Stevenson. "Listening to the community and responding to their needs is essential in making Thamesmead a safer place."

The officers will be working closely with Gallions and will be receiving regular updates from Response Centre staff and housing coordinators. So if you see any anti-social behaviour or criminal activity, you can call Gallions on Freephone 0800 838481 and the information will be passed on to the police team. If you require immediate police attendance then please dial 999.

'Lift Surfers' Risk Lives

Children are putting themselves at risk by breaking into lift shafts and 'surfing' on the roofs of the lifts in Thamesmead, especially within the blocks of Byron Close.

The 'lift surfers' risk injuring both themselves and any unsuspecting passengers inside the lifts. They also risk damaging the lifts, causing great inconvenience to residents if a lift becomes inoperable. Repairs to damaged lifts are often very expensive, leading to increases in service charges and rents.

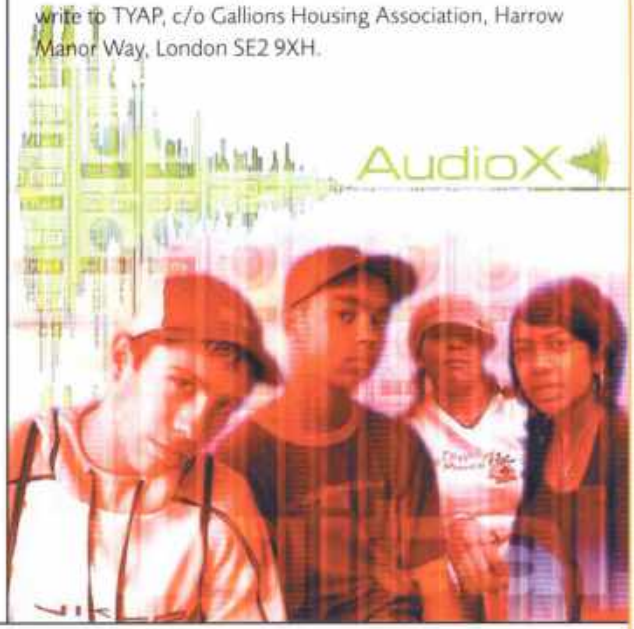
If you have any information about interference with lifts, please phone 0800 83 84 81.

Music Training Opportunities!

Thamesmead Youth Awareness Programme's Audio X course started again on 20 October. If you live in SE2, SE28 or DA18, you can achieve a London Open College Network certificate for the course. If you live in the wider Bexley and Greenwich Boroughs you can gain an in-house certificate of achievement.

Other opportunities at TYAP for 16-25s include steel drum lessons, street dance, DJ/MC lessons, use of a recording studio, drug awareness groups, personal development, Broadband Internet access and volunteering opportunities.

To find out more about any of the items listed above, or to book a taster session, contact Aminia on 020 8311 5111 or write to TYAP, c/o Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.





A big Thanks! to the many Thamesmead East residents who have filled out and returned a household survey giving them the chance to have their say on crime and community safety in the area.

Council Leader Chris Ball, Chair of Bexley's Community Safety Partnership, said, "I am delighted to see the residents of Thamesmead taking such a positive and active interest in helping to make their area a safer place in which to live."

GALLIONS IN THE

COMMUNITY

From the Neighbourhood Wardens to the Gallions Residents Board, Gallions is striving to make a difference to the quality of life of people living in Thamesmead. Here Grapevine looks at how Gallions has become far more than just a normal social landlord.



Warden Races

Three of Thamesmead's dedicated Neighbourhood Wardens were at Peckham town centre recently to demonstrate four of their radio controlled Subaru Impreza model cars. The WRCCC (Wardens' Radio Controlled Car Club) has proved a big success in Thamesmead, and the organisers hoped it would also be popular in Peckham.

The Peckham Street Wardens Project Manager used the event to introduce the WRCCC to Peckham's local youth and register the names of those that were interested. Altogether 60 new members registered, making the day a great success.

The aim of the project is to divert local youths away from anti-social behaviour by providing them with alternative activities. Thamesmead and Abbey Wood Wardens will be helping the Peckham Wardens organise and set up their own Radio Car Club as a division of the WRCCC.

Get involved!

To get involved in the Wardens' Radio Controlled Car Club, check out www.wrccc.org.uk. You can also find out about other fun activities at www.wardensweb.co.uk Call 0208 320 3441 for more details.



Pedal Power

The Wardens recently took to the streets on four mountain bikes, bought with money donated by the Abbey Wood Forum.
The bikes were purchased at Halfords in Charlton, after the Manager agreed to support the Wardens by giving them a generous discount on the bikes and accessories! Halfords also donated four Giro cycle helmets free of charge to help keep the Wardens safe.

The mountain bikes will allow the Wardens to cover the area more quickly than they could on foot. The new transport has also proved a great talking point between the Wardens and members of the community.

Wardens Give Santa Helping Hand

On Christmas Eve this year, Santa had a few extra helpers in Thamesmead. The Neighbourhood Wardens may not have dressed up as elves, but they were still full of Christmas spirit when they distributed hampers to the elderly and vulnerable in Abbey Wood and Thamesmead.
The Wardens collected perishable and non-perishable food items from the LBG offices at Birchmere Depot, the Housing Office in Eynsham Drive and Gallions Housing Association. Local stores ALDI and Kwik Save also donated cartons of assorted tinned food. Staff and members of the community made cash donations, and the Wardens used these to buy more food items, which they made up into hampers. The success of last year's efforts encouraged the Wardens to continue the tradition this year. As expected, the recipients of the hampers were equally overjoyed with their Christmas Eve surprise!

The GRB needs YOU

GALLIONS RESIDENTS' BOARD

Last year the Gallions Residents Board was referred to by one member of the community as 'The Faceless Committee'. So one of the Board's goals this year is to raise its profile in the community. To help it along, Grapevine has put a face to each member of the GRB and tried to explain exactly what they all do!

The Gallions Residents Board (GRB) continues to be an important source of ideas and opinions. Last year it was consulted on a number of issues, including the Neighbourhood Wardens project, the draft of the Tenants' Handbook, the Gallions Business Plan and the selection of a new maintenance contractor, AXIS PLC.

But despite these efforts, some residents still don't fully understand what the GRB does. More importantly, they don't know how they can become involved in the GRB's work. Here Grapevine unravels the mystery and explains how tenants can help the GRB.

What is it?
The Gallions Residents Board (GRB) is an elected body of Gallions Housing Association's Tenants and Leaseholders.

What does it do?
GRB members are residents who have been elected by other residents. Their main role is to represent the views of the residents to the Gallions Housing Association.

The GRB's work with Gallions
The GRB works closely with Gallions staff and holds regular meetings with the Director of Customer Services, who is responsible for introducing any proposed changes to policy, or any other changes that may affect residents.

Training
Training is very important to the GRB. All new members have to sign a form agreeing to do training, which covers things like committee skills and representing the community.

Thoughts for the future
The GRB wants to carry on working and building trust in the community. This can sometimes be hard, because most of its work is carried out behind the scenes. The GRB needs your help and thoughts on what it can do to help support the community, so if you're interested call Linda Nash on 0208 320 3451

Who's who?


Don Tidy


Dub-Adams Hambo


Patricia Wallington


Peter Houching


Norma Mthetwa


Graham Horton


Pauline Oates


Kola Ayanwale


Kay Burton


Joanne Bernard


Ken Sealey


Joyce Couchman

Other members include Tokky Ademoyero, Jim Flynn, Terry Graves, Tom Nash and Freda Mc Ewan.

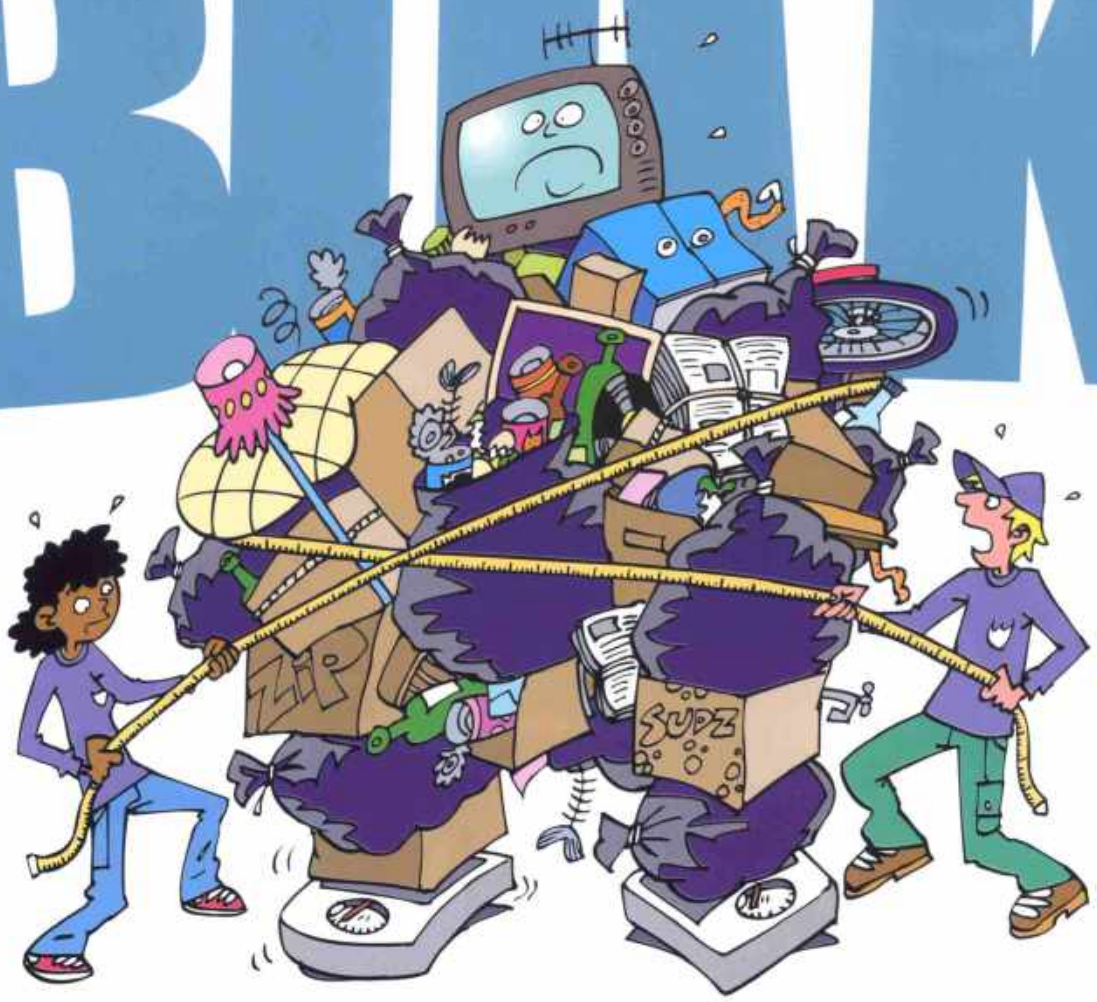
Team Gallions
ENVIRONMENTAL SERVICES

It was Christmas morning, and what were the guys and gals of Team Gallions doing? Well, 17 of them were hauling trash. Over the two days of Christmas, Team Gallions filled eight massive skips with rubbish. It is becoming a major problem, not just for Team Gallions, but for all the residents of Thamesmead.

It's amazing how much stuff we all throw away. This January, Team Gallions organised a rubbish amnesty and collected five tons of dead and dying furniture, TVs, prams, pushchairs and carpets. The Team even had a couple of requests to take away an ex-husband!

But the Team shouldn't really be doing this kind of thing, since it just wastes time and money. Team Gallions pay £180,000 a year in tipping fees, and the money could be better spent around Thamesmead. Meanwhile the rubbish piles up. There has to be a better way.

The Incredible BULK



PICS BY SEAN LONGCROFT

Beat the BULK

The main problem is bulk rubbish, like old sofas and TVs. It would really help if you could take things like this to the Greenwich tip in Nathan Way. Or if you are a Bexley resident and don't want to pay the fee at Nathan Way, take it to the Thames Road tip in Bexley. You can also phone your local council and ask them take it away.



Here are a few ways you can beat the bulk.

- **Don't let it build up. Get rid of it.**
- **Get together with a neighbour and borrow or even hire a van.**
- **Remember that you can get rid of a lot of stuff by recycling it.**
- **Pin up the council's number.**

Bexley:
020 8303 7777
Greenwich:
020 8854 8888

PICS BY SEAN LONGCROFT



Three Wishes

If a genie could grant three wishes, Team Gallions would ask that:

- **all small rubbish is placed in dustbins, or down the chute.**
- **all bulk rubbish disappears down the tip, or into a council truck.**
- **all dogs owners clean up after their dogs.***

*Remember that free scoop-the-poop bags are available from Team Gallions' staff and from the Gallions' offices.





Work Experience

Many people needing work experience or training have had a chance to prove their worth with Team Gallions. Several have even gone on to become valuable permanent staff members.

Recently, long-term unemployed from the Bromley Field Studies Centre helped with clearing a section of canal and cutting back the reeds. It was hard work, and Team Gallions would like to thank them for doing it in such a professional way.

Bulbs Beautiful Bulbs

Young volunteers from the Prince's Trust did a terrific job planting shrubs and bulbs in the gardens of Buckwheat Court, Shire Court and Teeswater Court in December.

The volunteers were unemployed 16–25 year olds, on a 12-week training and work experience programme with the Trust. They came up with the idea of brightening up the gardens for the elderly, and met the residents to discuss it. Then they worked hard to plant 1500 bulbs and about 100 plants supplied by Team Gallions. Now we just have to wait for spring.

Leave Ho!

Team Gallions were hoping that their wonderful new litter-removing machine would help with the task of sweeping up the leaves of Thamesmead's 20,000 trees this year. It was fine while the leaves were dry, but when they got wet they clogged up the works! The Team started again with extra blowers and tractor-drawn suction equipment. Eventually they filled 12 enormous skips, three weeks ahead of schedule. They are now looking at ways of composting leaves and green waste to cut the costs of disposal.







The Tavy Bridge of the Future?



In the summer of 2003, the residents of Tavy Bridge were asked to comment on two design options for the redevelopment of the area. Here we publish the plans for the first time, and comment on what the future has in store for Tavy Bridge.



All photographic images are examples of how Tavy Bridge could look in the future, we are not at this stage saying that this is what it will look like.



At last the plans for the regeneration of Tavy Bridge are here, and the preferred option is now being developed into a planning application. The residents of Tavy Bridge have always shown their support for the regeneration of the estate, and they are now keen to see the work get under way.

Questionnaires and consultation sessions have revealed that Tavy Bridge residents like the area, the view, the balconies, the lake and their neighbours. Most importantly, they want to stay in the redeveloped area.

Their main complaints were about the environment, rubbish and anti-social behaviour. Their most popular demand was for more activities for children and young people.

There is overwhelming support for demolishing the underground car park and refurbishing existing buildings. Residents also like the idea of the park over the lake, and making the corner of Yarnton Way and Harrow Manor Way the focal point of shops and offices.

At this stage, the clear message from residents is 'just get on with it'. So a great deal of work is now going on behind the scenes to get things moving.

The key elements of the preferred option are:

- A high-density development of new apartments and facilities, together with the refurbishment of north Binsey Walk, Tilehurst Point and Blewbury House.
- New links through north Binsey Walk to the lake.
- A community focus, incorporating the new Health Centre, the Gallions Housing Association offices and relocated shops, at the corner of Yarnton Way and Harrow Manor Way.
- A deck covering the southern portion of the lake, creating a new lakeside park and amenity space.
- A series of amenity spaces leading from the streets to the lake.
- On-street parking providing natural surveillance, and no dark undercrofts.

These images represent the current preferred option designs for the redevelopment of Tavy Bridge. Gallions reserves the right to change the designs in the future in consultation with residents.



The regeneration of Tavy Bridge will mean:

- Comfortable, safe and secure homes with improved interiors.
- A range of rented and owner-occupied housing.
- Improved health facilities.
- Employment and training opportunities.
- Opportunities for lifelong learning.
- A vibrant and sustainable living environment.
- An estate that is part of a diverse local community.
- Reduced crime levels and increased perception of safety.
- Tavy Bridge remains a place where people choose to live
- The building of new homes for private sale.

The building work required includes:

- The refurbishment of 173 Gallions' homes.
- The demolition and rebuilding of 153 Gallions' homes.
- A new health centre.
- A new Gallions office building.
- New community buildings and facilities.

The Tavy Bridge team is also consulting with Bexley Council about moving the library to a more central location. This would help create a one-stop information zone for residents combining the library, the Gallions' reception office, the community centre and possibly a police post.

There will also be a number of community projects running alongside the main regeneration project.

Gallions are working in partnership with Wates Construction and have jointly appointed Broadway Malyan as Project Architects.

If you'd like further information regarding this project, please do not hesitate to visit our project office at Tavy Bridge (the old bank unit). Alternatively, you can contact Debbie Withall, Project Manager on 020 8310 8770 or 020 8310 1500 ext 236.

New 'Pay As You Go' Home Contents Insurance

Gallions is pleased to announce the launch of a new affordable home contents insurance scheme for all tenants and leaseholders. The scheme is very different from the usual contents insurance policies.

What's Good About It?

All residents are guaranteed cover wherever they live. There are no 'high risk postcodes'.
There is no need to have special locks or security devices fitted.

There is no 12-month contract. The cover is 'pay as you go', just like a mobile phone.
You pay in cash at the post office fortnightly, or by direct debit monthly.

How Much?

Below are some example of premiums and sums insured. A full information pack with all the premiums quoted is available on request (see the contact details below).

SUM INSURED	FORTNIGHTLY	MONTHLY	ANNUAL
£6,000	£2.23	£3.64	£43.68
£9,000	£3.07	£5.46	£65.52
£12,000	£3.91	£7.28	£87.36

To find out more and get a free information pack please telephone Zoe Thomas on 0208 310 1500, Ext 384

Leasehold Forum

The Gallions' Leasehold Forum has been active for over 18 months now. It provides our Leaseholders with a place to discuss issues that affect them as a group, and find ways of improving services for Gallions Leaseholders.

It is NOT a forum for individual problems.

The Leasehold Forum meets four times a year, and would welcome new members. If you would like to join or require more information please contact Lynn Bekir on 020 8320 3460.

ATTENTION KEY WORKERS

Here's something to make you smile in the new year

Up to £50,000*
towards a brand new home of your own



Choose from a stunning selection of 1 and 2 bedroom apartments at:
Priory Place, Felixstowe Road, SE2
Prices start from just £128,500**

What are you waiting for?

Call the Sales Team at Gallions NOW to book you appointment on 020 8320 3494 or email homes@gallionsha.co.uk

GALLIONS HOUSING ASSOCIATION

**one bedroom apartment with private garden and parking space

*Represents the maximum equity loan available to key workers working in the Greater London area to purchase a brand new apartment at Priory Place. You pay nothing on the loan and it is only repayable if you sell - you then pay back the equivalent % of the value of the property at the time it is sold. Full and detailed financial information will be provided upon request. This offer is open to NHS staff, teachers, metropolitan police, fire fighters, prison officers, social workers, probation officers etc.

Pay to Stay!

Your questions answered about rent and service charges



What is a Notice of Seeking Possession? (and what to do if you get one)

There have been 740 Notice of Seeking Possession's served so far this year. 19 Outright Possession orders have been awarded and another 44 suspended possession orders. **There have also been 47evictions**.

What happens if a tenant has rent arrears and...

- The debt continues to rise
- Or the debt doesn't reduce
- Or the tenant does not contact their revenue officer to make an agreement to reduce the arrears
- Or makes an agreement but then does not pay.

Initially letters will be sent urging the tenant to rectify the situation but if the position does not change it is likely that Gallions will serve a Notice of Seeking Possession on the tenant(s).

A Notice of Seeking Possession is a legal document setting out the grounds (the breaches of tenancy regarding payment of rent) Gallions would rely on if they issue possession proceedings at the county court. After a notice is served it does not become effective for 4 weeks, during this time the tenant has another opportunity to make contact and explain the circumstances that led to the arrears. The revenue officer may not be aware of a change in the tenant's circumstances, or the tenant could make an arrangement to pay off the debt by instalments or may even pay it off altogether during this time. If the debt is repaid in full the notice is no longer valid.

A Notice of Seeking Possession is valid for 1 year while arrears remain on the rent account. If possession proceedings have not been issued during this time and the rent account deteriorates again a new Notice of Seeking Possession will need to be served before any further action can commence.

On the whole there are 2 different tenancies with Gallions :

Secure Tenancies
Tenants whose first tenancy on Thamesmead began when the Greater London Council or the London Residuary Body managed Thamesmead.

Assured Tenancies
Tenancies that began after 15/01/89.

The 2 different tenancies are governed by different housing acts and so the grounds on the Notice of Seeking Possession will be different. The ground for possession of Assured tenancies has the only Mandatory ground. This means if the case were to proceed to court the Judge would have no choice but to grant outright possession to Gallions if that was the order that Gallions was seeking. This can happen if there are 8 weeks or more rent outstanding when the notice was served and there remained the same 8 or more weeks rent outstanding on the day of the hearing. If Gallions was relying on any of the other standard grounds the Court would decide if the order Gallions is seeking is reasonable based on the evidence supplied by Gallions and the tenant.

If you receive or have already received any arrears letters and have not contacted us – please do so now! If you have received a Notice of Seeking Possession you should contact us immediately but you may wish to seek independent advice this can be obtained free from Thamesmead Law Centre or the Housing Aid Centre in Woolwich.

Incentive Scheme
Thank you to all residents who completed and returned the questionnaire in the last issue of Grapevine. We received 200 responses from you. The results will be in the next issue of Grapevine.

Board information

The next board meeting will be held on 13/03/04 at the Harrow Manor Way Offices. All meetings are open to residents and if you are interested in attending please let Averyl Richards know on 0208 320 3410 or email her at arichards@gallions.co.uk

Race and Diversity Review

Kay Vowels, Acting Director of Operations recently distributed the Housing Corporations report on race and cultural diversity at Gallions to the Board. The report was a ringing endorsement of Gallions strategy and future plans. Chairman Aman Dalvi said it was really pleasing to receive the paper and that the staff of Gallions should be congratulated for an excellent report, and in particular Tokky Ademoyero for the work he is doing as Champion for Diversity. Ms Vowles said the action plan is being implemented and the Board will receive a six-monthly report from EaDiP.

Contact us

Gallions Housing Association
Harrow Manor Way
London
SE2 9XH

Customer Response Centre Freephone
0800 83 84 81

This freephone number is now taking all calls to Gallions via the Customer Response Centre, this also includes switchboard calls.

The old switchboard number will be withdrawn in the coming months.

Feedback

We welcome your suggestions and comments on how we can improve our services and make your environment and home a better place to live in. Simply send your comments to:-
Feedback, Gallions Grapevine, Perry André, Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH.

Don't forget to add your name, address and telephone number for contact details or alternatively email me on pandre@gallionsha.co.uk

ਜੇ ਅੰਗਰੇਜ਼ੀ ਤੁਹਾਡੀ ਪਹਿਲੀ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਨਹੀਂ, ਅਤੇ ਤੁਸੀਂ ਇਸ ਦਸਤਾਵੇਜ਼ ਦਾ ਤਰਜਮਾ ਚਾਹੁੰਦੇ ਹੋ, ਤਾ ਕਿਰਪਾ ਕਰਕੇ ਆਪਣੀ ਚੁਣੀ ਹੋਈ ਭਾਸ਼ਾ ਦੇ ਨਾਂ ਦੇ ਨੇੜੇ ਵਾਲੇ ਖ਼ਾਨੇ ਵਿਚ ਸਹੀ ਦਾ ਨਿਸ਼ਾਨ ਲਾ ਕੇ, ਅਤੇ ਦੱਸੀ ਹੋਈ ਥਾਂ 'ਤੇ ਆਪਣਾ ਨਾਂ ਅਤੇ ਪਤਾ ਲਿਖ ਕੇ ਇਹ ਫ਼ਾਰਮ ਕਿਸੇ ਲਿਫ਼ਾਫ਼ੇ ਵਿਚ ਪਾ ਕੇ ਹੇਠ ਲਿਖੇ ਪਤੇ 'ਤੇ ਭੇਜ ਦਿਓ।

如果英語不是您的母語，您希望將該文件翻譯出來的話，請在您選擇的語言旁邊打勾，請在所示之處填上您的姓名和地址，併用信封將本表格寄到下列地址。

Nếu Anh ngữ không phải là ngôn ngữ chính, Quý vị muốn dịch tài liệu này, xin vui lòng đánh dấu vào ô kế bên ngôn ngữ Quý vị chọn, ghi tên và địa chỉ vào nơi chỉ dẫn và gởi mẫu vào phong bì theo địa chỉ dưới đây.

PUNJABI ☐ **CHINESE** ☐ **VIETNAMESE** ☐ *(please tick one)*

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

Return to: Caroline Wilson (Translation Requests), Gallions Housing Association, Harrow Manor Way, London SE2 9XH

News for the over-60s

Register of Paid Helpers

The aim of the Register of Paid Helpers is to provide a service to elderly people and their carers and to undertake a diversity of tasks for them.Paid helpers are professionals such as decorators, domestic helpers, gardeners, handy men and plumbers.

When the Paid Helpers list is requested and sent out to people, a covering letter is included giving information regarding the service. Before helpers are registered with the organisation, references are requested and a police check is carried out. All helpers are also issued with an Identity Card.

Please telephone Age Concern Greenwich on 0208 854 6079 for more details.

Bexley Council for Racial Equality

In order to promote awareness of mental health for the Chinese and Vietnamese Communities in Bexley, a meeting on depression has been organised.

Tuesday, 16 March 2004, 11am-12.30pm.
Atrium Hall,
Teeswater Court,
Mangold Way,
Thamesmead,
DA18, 4DG

Speaker:
Dr. Cam Nguyen
Vietnamese Mental Health services.
(The meeting will be conducted in Vietnamese and translated into Cantonese)

Please come and join us to find out more.

For more information please contact: Ngoc Lan Ly, 1 Maran Way, Thamesemead.Tel: 0208 312 0559.